

5. ABBOT OF CANTERBURY

BY ANONYMOUS

"King John and the Abbot of Canterbury", which is a ballad from medieval English literature. It is an anonymous work, focusing on a humorous and satirical exchange between King John and the Abbot of Canterbury. The king, hearing of the Abbot's wealth and lavish lifestyle, challenges him to explain how he can afford such luxuries. The Abbot cleverly responds that he only spends his own money, thus avoiding any accusations of corruption.

An ancient story I'll tell you anon
Of a notable prince that was called King John;
And he ruled England with main and with might,
For he did great wrong, and maintained little right.

And I'll tell you a story, a story so merrie,
Concerning the Abbot of Canterbury;
How for his housekeeping and high renown,
They rode post for him to fair London town.

EXERCISE 1- POST READING

Q1) What story has been stated in the poem "The Abbot of Canterbury"?

Answer: The poem Abbot of Canterbury is a traditional form of Ballad. It is a southern form of ballad. The story is about the quarrel and controversy between King John and the Abbot of Canterbury. King John, who was an autocrat, ruled England from 1199 to 1216, by his cruelty and powers and wanted to control all over the people .he had heard about the living standard and the growing fame of the Abbot of Canterbury. He had heard about the Abbot's great reputation and wealth. He had also heard that Abbot entertained a hundred men in his house everyday, so he shared good relations with common men. So he got envious and jealous and asked him to come to his palace to answer three riddles to save his life.

Q2) Why did King John summon the Abbot to his court?

Answer: King John who ruled England because of his power and cruelty and when had heard about the lavish living standard and growing rapidly fame of the Abbot of Canterbury so he had become anxious and he got fear of treachery so out of the jealousy he called to his court and accused him of defiance for which he decided to punish him.

Q3) What were the three questions of King John?

Answer: The three questions of King John, which were asked to answer the Abbot in order to save his life, were:

1. What was the worth of King John when he was sitting on his throne?
2. How soon could he travel around the world?
3. What was the King thinking at that time?

Q4) What efforts did the Abbot make in order to save himself?

Answer: When King John charged Abbot with treason due to his pompous life, Abbot tried to explain him that he was innocent and all the wealth which he spends is rightly earned. He has earned his wealth and fame through his own hardwork. But the King did not listen.

Q5. What was the reaction of Abbot on hearing King's questions?

Answer: The Abbot had become much anxious, listening to all of those difficult questions of King John because he was not able to answer those at that moment. So he asked three week space and tried very best to get the most possible answers and for that he went to Cambridge and Oxford but he could not get any wise man who could devise the answers by his skill.

Q6. What was the punishment that King John announced for the Abbot?

Answer: King John announced the bitter punishment for the Abbot that he would smite his neck from his body and would seize his property as a penalty if he could not answer his complicated questions. The reason behind that King John had much fear by the growing fame of the Abbot and thought that he would treason against his crown.

Q7. Who tried to help the Abbot out and up to what extent was he successful?

Answer: When the Abbot was in search of the best answers of those three difficult questions of King and before three days of ending his space, he was returning towards home disappointed and depressed so he met his shepherd and told him a complete story. The shepherd was much confident after knowing the questions and assured the Abbot that if he would change him to go there to answer those questions as his imposter so he could give and if he failed so his head would be smitten instead of him and he was quite successful that the King announced to reward him four nobles a week.

Q8. How did the shepherd save the Abbot's life? OR Describe the intelligent answers given by the poor shepherd to King John in the poem, 'The Abbot of Canterbury'.

Answer: The King asked the Abbot three complicated questions because he felt jealousy with the Abbot's lifestyle and his rising followers. He also did a condition that if Abbot would fail to give the answers to these questions so his head will be smitten with his body.

The Abbot researched a lot to get the answers but there was not a wise person who could devise answers. He met his shepherd who after listening to those questions, took his permission to answer King's questions. He disguised himself as Abbot and presented himself before the King.

He answered the first question that Jesus Christ, our Savoir was sold in thirty pence among the false Jews so your worth should be less one penny than to him. Hence your worth was twenty-nine pence.

He answered the second question that if you got up with the sun and rode with the sun so you could easily travel the whole world in twenty-four hours. To the third question, he answered that you thought that the Abbot was answering you but he was his poor shepherd saying this he took off his grab.

Q9. Describe the main idea or the central idea of the poem, Abbot of Canterbury.

Answer: The main idea of the poem Abbot of Canterbury centers on the famous saying 'DO NOT JUDGE A BOOK BY ITS COVER'. People must not be judged wise or intelligent on the basis of their knowledge and appearance. Knowledge is obtained from books but wisdom is obtained through experience. Wisdom comes with analysis of life through personal experiences. So, the lesson learnt is that wisdom is not a blessing of knowledge, it is a blessing of God.